

Coping Intelligence: Coping Strategies and Organizational Commitment Among Boundary Spanning Employees

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Abstract In this study, we develop a new theoretical framework of Coping Intelligence (CI) which examines relationships between coping strategies and organizational commitment among boundary spanning employees. We collected data from 452 boundary spanning salespeople using multiple sources. Results demonstrate that a formative model of Coping Intelligence (CI) is superior to a reflective model and that problem-focused coping contributes to CI which, in turn, is related to affective and normative commitment. Further, our more parsimonious formative model illustrates that positive problem-focused coping and negative emotion-focused coping contribute to both affective and normative commitment. After controlling for gender and salespeople's commission (from company's personnel record) in separate analyses, results remain significant. We provide additional insights: Females are likely to use emotion-focused coping than males, but gender is not related to organizational commitment. Salespeople's commission is positively related to both affective and normative commitment but unrelated to coping strategies. We shed new lights on boundary spanning employees' Coping Intelligence and organizational commitment and offer theoretical, empirical, and practical implications to coping strategies and business ethics.

Keywords Stress · Boundary spanning · Coping strategies · Problem-focused · Action-focused · Emotion-focused · Coping intelligence · Organizational commitment · Affective · Continuance · Normative · Gender · Sales commission · Ethics

Introduction

According to Hans Selye, the father of stress research, "stress is defined as *the nonspecific response of the body to any demand*" (Selye 1978, p. 55). The National Institute of Occupational Safety and Health defines stress as "harmful physical and emotional responses that occur when the requirements of the job do not match the capabilities, resources, or needs of the worker" (1999, p. 1). The World Health Organization called stress the "health epidemic of the 21st century" which is estimated to cost businesses up to \$300 billion a year (Smith 2012). In fact, three out of every four employees describe their work as stressful.

Stress affects all employees at work (Jamal 1984; Tang and Hammontree 1992), boundary spanners, in particular. Boundary spanning employees engage in "job-related interactions with a person who is considered part of the environment" and "not a member of the organization" (Robertson 1995, p. 75). These employees play an important role in organizations (Edmondson and Boyer 2013; Jolson et al. 1993; Singh 1993; Singh et al. 1996) and include not only salespeople but also any customer-contact employees (McNeilly and Russ 1992; Russ et al. 1996; Singh et al. 1996). Working under the constraints of the internal as well as the external environment (Goolsby 1992; Pruden and Reese 1972), boundary spanning employees are responsible for delivering quality products and services, customer satisfaction, and performance of the

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organizations (Hartline and Ferrell 1996; Mulki et al. 2012). They face a high level of work-related stress and try to cope with their stress.

Why do some salespeople cope with stress better than others? The answer lies in their ability to select the proper coping strategies that enhance their commitment. “Coping behavior is a major component in the relationship between the experience of stress and adaptational outcomes such as poor psychological health and physical symptoms” (Oakland and Ostell 1996, p. 133). Coping entails a behavior or process that people use to rectify strains associated with chronic job stress (Lazarus and Folkman 1984). Among different ways of coping with stress (Ivancevich and Matteson 1986; Lewin and Sager 2008; Moos 1993), Carver et al. (1989) identified three types of coping strategies: problem-focused coping (PFC), emotion-focused coping (EFC), and other dysfunctional coping (mental and behavioral disengagement). Later, researchers tended to pay more attention to problem-focused coping and emotion-focused coping and less to dysfunctional coping (Boyd et al. 2009; Srivastava and Sager 1999; Strutton and Lumpkin 1993).

Problem-focused coping (active coping) involves salespersons’ researching the sources of stress, generating alternatives, weighing the alternatives in terms of costs and benefits to self and organization, and selecting an alternative based on the balance between costs and benefits (Tang 2014a; Tang et al. 1987, 1989). Emotion-focused coping (avoidance coping) involves salespersons’ governing the emotions by regulating and reducing emotional distress (Folkman et al. 1986; Goolsby 1992; Jex et al. 2001; Strutton and Lumpkin 1993, 1994; Strutton et al. 1995). On the one hand, employees’ inability to cope with the stress leads to poor performance, reduction in job satisfaction, burnout, and poor organizational commitment (Tang and Hammontree 1992). On the other hand, successful coping strategies may enhance their commitment to the organization. Organizational commitment (Allen and Meyer 1990) is important to individuals and organizations (Cunningham et al. 2012) because high organizational commitment curbs unethical intentions and behaviors and other negative consequences and promotes job performance, acceptance of organizational goals and values, organizational citizenship behavior, and other positive outcomes (Brett et al. 1995; Judge et al. 1999; Tang and Chiu 2003; Wright and Bonett 1993).

Following theory of Monetary Intelligence (MI, money smart, e.g., Chen et al. 2013; Lemrová et al. 2013; Tang 2014b; Tang and Sutarso 2013; Tang et al. 2013), Sardžoska and Tang (2014) explored MI and the relationships between affective, behavioral, and cognitive (ABC) components of money attitudes and coping strategies and unethical intentions. Based on 515 Macedonian managers,

positive affective love of money motive (MI-A) and *positive* stewardship behavior (MI-B) are related to stronger behavioral and cognitive “approach” coping strategies and weaker behavioral and cognitive “avoidance” coping strategies. Further, their *negative* stewardship behavior (MI-B) and *positive* cognitive meaning (MI-C) lead to unethical intentions. Following theory of MI and related research on coping, we attempt to extend Sardžoska and Tang’s work.

In this study, we propose a theoretical model of coping intelligence (CI) which explores the relationships between coping strategy and organizational commitment and also treat gender and sales performance as control variables. We collect data from multiple sources: survey data from 452 salespeople and their sales performance (commission) from the organization’s official personnel records. Results support our theoretical model of coping intelligence (CI) and provide the following theoretical and practical contributions. First, using a formative model, *positive* problem-focused coping strategy and *negative* emotion-focused coping strategy contribute to CI which, in turn, is positively related to both affective and normative commitment. Further, when we control gender and sales commission in two separate analyses, our model offers additional insights: Females are likely to use emotion-focused coping than males. However, gender is not related to organizational commitment. Salespeople’s commission is positively related to both affective and normative commitment, but, interestingly enough, unrelated to coping strategies. This study sheds new lights on boundary spanning employees’ coping intelligence, organizational commitment, gender difference, and sales performance and offers practical implications to business ethics as well.

Theory and Hypotheses

Job Stress and Ethical Climate

Salespeople are affected by two critical stressors: customer demands and ethical demands (Goolsby 1992). Due to multiple stakeholders and ethical situations, they experience high levels of stress (Evans et al. 2012; Mulki et al. 2008). Although the overall stress may be the same, salespeople adopt different coping strategies and some manage their job stress and strain better than others (Behrman and Perreault 1984; Lazarus and Folkman 1984; Strutton and Lumpkin 1993, 1994). Researchers attempt to identify coping strategies for salespeople that yield positive outcomes in organizations (e.g., higher performance, job satisfaction, organizational commitment). Scholars have studied and empirically tested the relationship between stress and job performance (Atteya 2012; Maslach 2003;

Muse et al. 2003). For those who advocate a positive relationship between job stress and performance, they equate stress with challenge. Employees who cope with it positively by performing constructive activities tend to improve their performance (Atteya 2012). Others advocate a negative relationship between job stress and performance and equate stress with negative environment at work. Employees, who cope with it negatively by avoiding it, exacerbate their performance-related problems (Atteya 2012; Cohen 1980). The relationships between coping and job outcomes may reflect both strategies and continue to generate interests for researchers (Belschak et al. 2006; Sardžoska and Tang 2012, 2014).

Job satisfaction is defined as a pleasurable emotional state resulting from the appraisal of one's job (Locke 1969). Stress has a negative effect on the employees' emotional state and thus reduces job satisfaction (Dorman and Zapf 2001). Coping, on the other hand, reduces the effect of stress which, in turn, may lead to higher job satisfaction (Karadal et al. 2008). Research also suggests that corporate ethical values (CEV) have a positive "double-whammy" effect: reducing employees' irritation (a symptom of stress) and enhancing their life satisfaction (Sardžoska and Tang 2009). Further, work-related stress may result in employees' illness and absenteeism (Tang and Hammontree 1992) and unethical intentions (Sardžoska and Tang 2009). Due to stress, some individuals may cut corners, produce low quality of products and/or services, lie about sickness, falsify accounting records, and deceive customers (Selart and Johansen 2011; Tang and Chen 2008). Successful salespeople with lower levels of stress are more like to act in an ethical manner than those with higher levels of stress (Jaramillo et al. 2011, 2013). Taken together, in this study, we explore coping intelligence (CI) and investigate the relationships between coping strategies and commitment which may provide important implications to researchers and practitioners regarding business ethics.

Coping Strategies

Coping mechanism helps salespeople reduce chronic job stress which leads to positive implicit outcomes: lessened depression, lower withdrawal intention, and increased performance (Edwards 1988, 1992; Folkman et al. 1986; Goolsby 1992; Latack 1986; Lewin and Sager 2009). Similar to Carver et al. (1989), Folkman and Lazarus (1985, 1988) and Lazarus and Folkman (1984) also identified two styles of coping strategies: (1) problem-focused coping (PFC or active coping) and (2) emotion-focused coping (EFC or avoidance coping) (Folkman et al. 1986; Srivastava and Sager 1999). Other dimensions (e.g., action-focused coping) have been proposed, but have received

little consistent support (Edwards 1992; Oakland and Ostell 1996). Various researchers subscribe to the bi-dimensional approach (Edwards 1988; Goolsby 1992; Jex et al. 2001; Strutton and Lumpkin 1993, 1994; Strutton et al. 1995). We define Coping Intelligence (CI) as a latent variable that reflects both problem-focused coping and emotional-focused coping.

In problem-focused coping (PFC), people identify the sources of stress, make an effort to remove it, seek positive outcomes, e.g., lower burnout, lower withdrawal intentions, higher job satisfaction, and higher performance. PFC reduces the daily job stress, makes it easier to work, and thus reduces the frustration with the job (Subramanian and Kumar 2012) which reduces employees' burnout. PFC also significantly reduces employee's turnover intentions (Lewin and Sager 2008). This leads to a significant saving for employers and significant reduction of daily stress for employees. PFC also leads to higher job satisfaction (Sardžoska and Tang 2012). If an employee is happy with the work environment and is able to reduce the daily job stress by using problem-focused coping, then the employee will be satisfied with the job. Job stress is one of the most noxious factors influencing job performance (Atteya 2012). In a meta-analysis study, Muse et al. (2003) supported a negative relationship between job stress and job performance. Problem-focused coping reduces job stress and enhances job performance.

In emotion-focused coping (EFC), individuals attempt to escape the stress rather than to remove it, leading to negative outcomes, e.g., higher burnout, higher withdrawal intentions, lower job satisfaction, and lower job performance. The employment of emotion-focused coping leads to a higher level of burnout (Lewin and Sager 2008). Over time, burnout leads to gradual depletion of individuals' energy and drive to work. When employees encounter daily stress at work, caused by job pressure or difficult customer, they frequently adopt the avoidance strategy. The failure to reduce job-related stress is one of the leading causes of turnover (Lewin and Sager 2008; Srivastava and Sager 1999). Employee turnover costs companies tremendously due to loss of productivity, morale, acquired knowledge, experience, and expertise and recurring costs for training and rehiring, among others (Lucas 2012; Tang et al. 2000). Evasive coping behavior increases emotional exhaustion and lower sense of pride at work. These employees do not contribute their share to the company and do not handle their work-related activity well, leading to lower job satisfaction (Chuang and Huang 2013; Sardžoska and Tang 2012). Stress also has a debilitating effect on employee's job performance. Due to unpleasant work environment caused by stress, employees spend a great deal of their time coping with stress. If employees use emotion-focused coping in dealing with their daily stress, their performance will suffer (Atteya 2012).

Organizational Commitment

Organizational commitment has three major components: affective, continuance, and normative (Allen and Meyer 1990). First, “the affective component” of organizational commitment refers to “employees’ emotional attachment to, identification with, and involvement in, the organization” (Allen and Meyer 1990, p. 1). Second, building upon side-bet theory (Becker 1960), continuance commitment is defined as a structural phenomenon that occurs “as a result of individual-organizational transactions and alternations in side-bets or investment over time” (Hrebiniak and Alutto 1972, p. 556). Employees’ side bets, or sunk costs (e.g., a pension plan) invested in the organization and occupation-specific skills bind them to an organization or occupation so that they cannot afford to leave. Finally, the normative component refers to “employees’ feelings of obligation to remain with the organization” (Allen and Meyer 1990, p. 1).

Commitment plays a major role in the performance of employees. Committed employees are able to handle the stress and become a positive influence at work and productive workers. The energizing nature of affective commitment leads to lower burnout as employees develop stronger bonds with their coworkers. That leads to reduced daily stress (Lapointe et al. 2012) and provides resources to carry out their work-related responsibilities. Affective commitment entails a sense of direction and purpose as well as confidence and self-esteem (Panaccio and Vandenberghe 2009). Employees with high affective commitment identify with the corporate goals and mission, desire to be part of the company, and deliver better job performance, resulting in higher job satisfaction (Budihardjo 2013) and lower turnover intention.

Continuance organizational commitment refers to the perceived costs individuals associate with leaving an organization (Allen and Meyer 1990; Brett et al. 1995; Meyer et al. 1993; Tang and Baldwin 1996). Employees with high continuance commitment focus on the long-term economic benefits for staying with the organization. This causes them to be much more positive in their attitude which leads to much lower burnout and much higher job satisfaction (Tang et al. 2012).

Normative organizational commitment refers to feelings of responsibility and obligation to remain with the organization (Allen and Meyer 1990; Meyer et al. 1993; Ozag 2006). This derives from individuals’ culture or work ethic (Tang and Baumeister 1984). The sense of loyalty and duty makes employees feel obligated to stay with the organization (Clugston 2000) and wanting to contribute more to the organization. Salespeople with higher normative

commitment perform better (Jaramillo et al. 2005; Meyer et al. 2002).

Coping Intelligence

In a recent study, Sardžoska and Tang (2014) explored the Monetary Intelligence (MI) construct and investigated the relationships between a formative model of money attitudes involving affective, behavioral, and cognitive (ABC) components and several sets of outcome variables—unethical intentions, intrinsic and extrinsic job satisfaction, and coping strategies. Based on 515 managers in the Republic of Macedonia, they revealed the following novel findings: Managers’ negative stewardship behavior (MI-B) and positive cognitive meaning (MI-C) define Monetary Intelligence (MI) which, in turn, is related to unethical intentions (corruption, theft, and resources abuse). Their multi-group analysis demonstrates that positive cognitive meaning (MI-C) enhances unethical intentions for managers in the public sector, whereas negative stewardship behavior (MI-B) promotes unethical intentions for those in the private sector. Those with positive stewardship behavior (MI-B) have high intrinsic and extrinsic job satisfaction. Managers’ positive affective love of money motive (MI-A) and stewardship behavior (MI-B) are significantly related to their stronger behavioral and cognitive “approach” coping strategies and weaker behavioral and cognitive “avoidance” coping strategies. Relationships among emotional intelligence, emotional coping ability, and organizational commitment exist (Humphreys et al. 2005).

People with high Monetary Intelligence monitor their own motives, behaviors, and cognitions and use the information to guide thinking and actions in their everyday lives (Sardžoska and Tang 2014). In the literature, only one study (Akhtayeva 2012) mentioned coping intelligence. The major purpose of the present study is to extend Sardžoska and Tang’s (2014) research, explore the notion of Coping Intelligence (CI), and investigate the relationships between a formative model of coping strategies involving problem-focused (CI-P), action-focused (CI-A), and emotion-focused (CI-E) components and outcome variables— affective (OC-A), continuance (OC-C), and normative (OC-N) commitment. We provide our rationale below. Money attitudes (MI-A, MI-B, and MI-C) are related to managers’ selection of coping behaviors. Similarly, scholars have examined three types of coping strategies (Edwards 1992; Folkman and Lazarus 1988; Lazarus and Folkman 1984; Oakland and Ostell 1996). These different types of coping strategies may have different consequences regarding their organizational commitment: affective, continuance, and normative commitment. Successful

coping behavior (problem-focused coping) leads to higher job satisfaction (Chuang and Huang 2013) which contributes to higher organizational commitment (Srivastava and Sager 1999). The use of emotion-focused coping, on the other hand, may lead to poor behaviors on the job and a lower level of organizational commitment (Srivastava and Sager 1999).

The negative influence of job stress on employee's daily work commitment is well researched (Leong et al. 1996; Orly et al. 2009). Affective commitment is related to employees' sense of belonging, attachment, and loyalty to the organization. Individuals with high Coping Intelligence tend to successfully reduce stress by using positive coping strategies which may lead to their positive experiences at work, i.e., high affective commitment (Mueller et al. 1992). Continuance commitment is an emotional reaction related to employees' feelings toward the cost of leaving the organization. Employees' positive Coping Intelligence may lead to their desire to stay with the organization, i.e., higher continuance commitment. Normative commitment reflects the sense of loyalty and the feeling that staying at the job is the right thing to do (Meyer et al. 1993). Employees with positive Coping Intelligence may also enhance their sense of loyalty and can affect the decision of staying at the job, i.e., higher normative commitment.

Hypothesis 1 Salespeople with high coping intelligence have high organizational commitment.

Formative Versus Reflective Model

For many decades, researchers have used the traditional reflective model for studying constructs (e.g., attitudes). Following a reflective model, causality flows from the latent constructs to observable items. The sub-constructs are considered as “an imperfect *reflection* of the underlying latent construct” (MacKenzie et al. 2011, p. 295). Direct manipulation of a particular indicator will *not* have an effect on the latent variable. Recent developments in measurement theories and research methodology help researchers develop formative theoretical models which treat sub-constructs as *distinguishable* perspectives, defining characteristics, or *formative* indicators of the overall latent construct (Coltman et al. 2008). Since sub-constructs are *not* interchangeable, the elimination of any single sub-construct will restrict the overall construct in a significant way. The direction of the relationship is from sub-constructs to the overall latent construct. Sub-constructs are the defining perspectives or independent contributors of the overall latent construct—Coping Intelligence. Further, researchers specify items, the first- and second-order sub-constructs as a reflective model.

We turn to our two control variables, gender and sales commission, next.

Gender

Some researchers found the effect of gender on the coping style (Akram and Mahmood 2013; Hampel and Petermann 2005); while others revealed little or no effect (Staempfli 2007). The effect of gender on job commitment is mixed (Hampel and Petermann 2005). Although some showed a significant effect of gender on commitment (Cunningham et al. 2012; Mathieu and Zajac 1990; Tang et al. 2012), most researchers claimed no significant effect (Al-Ajmi 2006; Ibrahim and Perez 2014; Marsden et al. 1993). Men and women have same level of affective commitment, continuance commitment, and overall organizational commitment; women, however, have higher normative commitment than men (Khalili and Asmawi 2012).

Performance (Sales Commission)

Both positive and negative relationships exist between stress and performance (Attaya 2012). Stress diminishes performance for some, but enhances it for others. Employees with a problem-focused coping reduce stress and have better performance; those with an emotion-focused coping may drop their performance (Compas et al. 2001; Clarke 2006). Those with high commission are more committed to the organization (Becker et al. 1996; Lee and Kamarul 2009). Individuals' objective performance (sales commission) may have an impact in our model. Results in the literature are mixed. Overall, we expect the same pattern of results will emerge after controlling for gender and sales commission in our theoretical model.

Method

Sample

We selected our sample of salespersons from the domestic U.S. sales force of an international manufacturer of specialty chemical products. We collected qualitative data from several sales managers regarding these boundary spanning salespeople at this organization and provided the following information: This manufacturer provides several lines of industrial maintenance chemicals, specialty lubricants, and other supply items. Sales managers referred to the company's sales process as the back-door selling because the salespeople targeted building engineers and others authorized ones to purchase \$5,000 - \$10,000 of specialty chemicals per year. These full-time salespeople are compensated through a full commission system. The

company uses internal systems for recruiting and training salespeople. Sales managers indicated that it takes three to six months for a salesperson to achieve basic proficiency, and 12 to 18 months to achieve full proficiency at the task aspect of the job. At the time of the study, this sales organization employed 1,200 salespeople and 100 sales managers arrayed into several geographic divisions. Twenty-five percent of salespeople were females, although females represent about 40 % of new hires. Eighty percent of the salespeople possessed a college degree or had partially completed college. Annual retention rate was slightly below 50 %.

A 10-page self-administered questionnaire was mailed to all 1,200 salespeople's homes. The survey booklet incorporated letters from the senior vice-president in charge of sales and the lead researcher. These letters summarized the rationale for the survey, assured the confidentiality of their personal identity in the research project, referenced a tracking number printed on the survey, and encouraged all participants to complete the survey. Researchers used the tracking number to match survey responses to performance data from the company's official records. Participants returned the survey in a postage-paid envelope addressed to the lead researcher at the university. We obtained responses from 452 salespeople (return rate = 37.67 %; males = 323, 72 %; females = 123, 28 %, with missing data). There were little differences in attitudes or behavior between male and female salespeople (e.g., Piercy et al. 2001). To assess the representativeness of the sample as related to the sales force as a whole, we compared late responders with early responders and found no significant differences between the two groups. Fifty-four percent of respondents had worked for the company for five or more years. Our sample had longer organizational tenure than the population, in general. Due to their long job tenure, it was appropriate for us to examine their coping strategies and organizational commitment in this study.

Measure

The components of Coping Intelligence, problem-focused coping (CI-P), action-focused coping (CI-A), and emotion-focused coping (CI-E), were measured using 33 items adapted from Folkman and Lazarus (1988) Ways of Coping Checklist. A five point Likert-type frequency response format was employed with the following scale anchors: *almost never* (1) to *almost always* (5). A higher score indicates greater usage of the coping strategy. We used Meyer et al. (1993) organizational commitment scale to measure affective (OC-A), continuance (OC-C), and normative (OC-N) commitment. We adopted a 7-point Likert-type scale with *strongly disagree* (1) and *strongly agree* (7) as scale anchors. The reliability (Cronbach's alpha) was as

follows: coping style: CI-P ($\alpha = .84$), CI-A (.72), and CI-E (.72) and organizational commitment: OC-A (.80), OC-C (.73), and OC-N (.85).

Results

Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 shows the mean, standard deviation, and correlations of all variables at the sub-construct level. Results showed that salespeople's average age was 45 years old (male = 73 %). Older (age) people tended to be male and did not use emotion-focused coping strategy. Problem-focused coping was negatively correlated with emotion-focused coping and positively associated with affective commitment. Emotion-focused coping was negatively related to affective commitment but positively related to normative commitment.

Measurement Model

We adopted the following rule for testing our measurement models. A model has a good fit, if results pass four of the following five criteria: (1) $\chi^2/df < 5$, (2) incremental fit index, IFI $> .90$, (3) Tucker–Lewis Index, TLI $> .90$, (4) comparative fit index, CFI $> .90$, (5) root mean square error of approximation, RMSEA $< .10$. RMSEA tends to over-reject a true model due to “small sample size” and “model complexity” (Tang et al. 2006a, p. 446).

Coping Strategy

Since Coping Intelligence (CI) is the most critical construct of this study, first, we established a *reflective* measurement model of coping strategies with 33 items and three first-order sub-constructs—problem-focused (CI-P), action-focused (CI-A), and emotion-focused (CI-E)—and one overall construct. For this confirmatory factor analysis (CFA), we found an inadequate fit between our measurement model and our data (Table 2, Model 1: $\chi^2 = 1,243.76$, $df = 492$, $p = .00$, $\chi^2/df = 2.51$, IFI = .70, TLI = .65, CFI = .69, RMSEA = .04). In order to identify an excellent fit, we must simplify our model. On the basis of our results in Model 1, we established a parsimonious model, identified three items each for problem-focused (CI-P), action-focused (CI-A), and emotion-focused (CI-E) coping strategies, and found an excellent fit (Table 2, Model 2, Fig. 1). For this CFA, the factor loadings of CI were as follows: problem-focused (CI-P = .33), action-focused (CI-A = $-.93$), and emotion-focused (CI-E = $-.73$).

Table 1 Mean, standard deviation, and correlations among variables

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1 Age	44.84	11.13							
2 Gender (% male)	.74	.95	.14**						
3 Problem-focused coping	3.71	.64	.07	.30					
4 Emotion-focused coping	2.23	-.90	-.17**	-.04	-.18**				
5 Affective commitment	27.98	6.35	.06	-.04	.26**	-.18**			
6 Normative commitment	20.33	4.99	.02	.03	-.04	.22**	.00		
7 Performance (commission)	10,418	7,555	.10	-.06	.03	-.04	-.03	-.04	

Gender: male = 1, female = 0

** $p < .01$ **Table 2** Main results of theoretical model

Model	χ^2	df	p	χ^2/df	IFI	TLI	CFI	RMSEA
<i>Measurement model</i>								
1 Coping strategies (whole scale)	1,243.76	452	.00	2.51	.70	.65	.69	.04
2 Coping strategies (refined)	37.47	24	.04	1.56	.98	.95	.98	.02
<i>Coping intelligence → outcomes</i>								
3 Organizational commitment (reflective, 3 outcomes)	202.58	51	.00	3.97	.79	.74	.83	.06
4 Organizational commitment (formative, 3 outcomes)	107.83	48	.00	2.25	.93	.89	.93	.04
5 Organizational commitment (reflective, 2 outcomes)	52.60	18	.00	2.92	.95	.89	.95	.05
6 Organizational commitment (formative, 2 outcomes)	45.08	17	.00	2.65	.96	.91	.96	.04
7 Organizational commitment (control for gender)	45.60	18	.00	2.53	.96	.90	.96	.04
8 Organizational commitment (control for performance)	68.02	18	.00	3.78	.90	.81	.92	.06

Common Method Variance (CMV)

The common method variance (CMV) problem may have been overstated and reached the status of urban legend in the literature (Spector 2006). Since we had cross-sectional survey data collected at one time, we adopted Harman's single-factor test to examine the CMV issue (Podsakoff et al. 2003). On the basis of our preliminary analyses above, we employed all 31 items of interests (gender, sales commission, 9 items of coping Strategy, and 20 items of organizational commitment) in an exploratory factor analysis (EFA) and set the number of factors to extract to one. The total amount of variance explained by one factor was 21.81 % which was significantly less than 50 %. Furthermore, based on Eigenvalue greater than one (1), we identified a total of 10 factors and the total amount of variance explained was 64.71 %. The largest amount of variance explained by Factor 1 was 21.81 % (and the other 9 factors were: 9.98, 6.24, 5.57, 4.13, 3.90, 3.58, 3.38, 3.10, and 3.02 %). Since no single factor accounted for more than 50 % of explained variance, CMV was not an issue. In addition, we attempted to avoid CMV bias (Podsakoff et al. 2003) by using different

response formats (scale anchors) for these measures. The concern for CMV is *not* warranted and that our measurement properties provide us high confidence in using these scales.

Coping Intelligence and Outcomes

We, now, turn to our Coping Intelligence (CI) construct. Coping Intelligence (CI) examines the relationships between three components of coping strategies—problem-focused (CI-P), action-focused (CI-A), and emotion-focused (CI-E) and three sub-constructs of organizational commitments—affectional commitment (OC-A), continuance commitment (OC-C), and normative commitment (OC-N), all at the sub-construct level. We compared our reflective model and formative model of Coping Intelligence (CI) below.

First, for our *reflective* model, Table 2, Model 3 (Fig. 2) shows Coping Intelligence's three first-order factors with factor loadings as follows: problem-focused coping (CI-P = .33), action-focused coping (CI-A = -.21) and emotion-focused coping (CI-E = -.23). In addition, CI was positively related to affectional commitment (OC-A = .88),

Fig. 1 Confirmation factor analysis (CFA) coping strategies

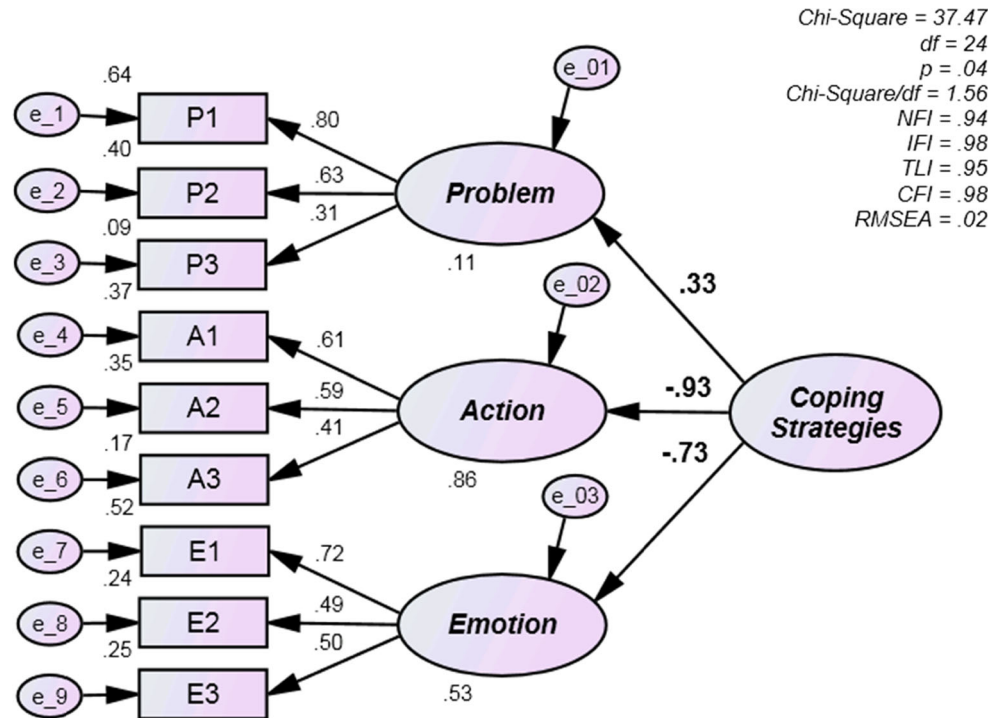
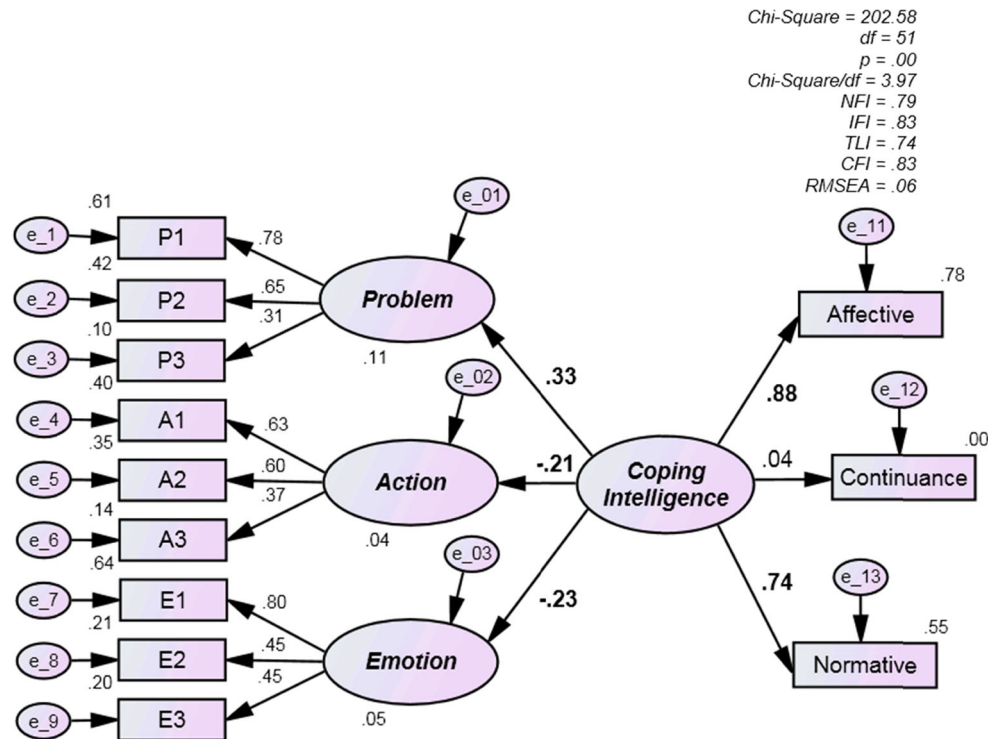


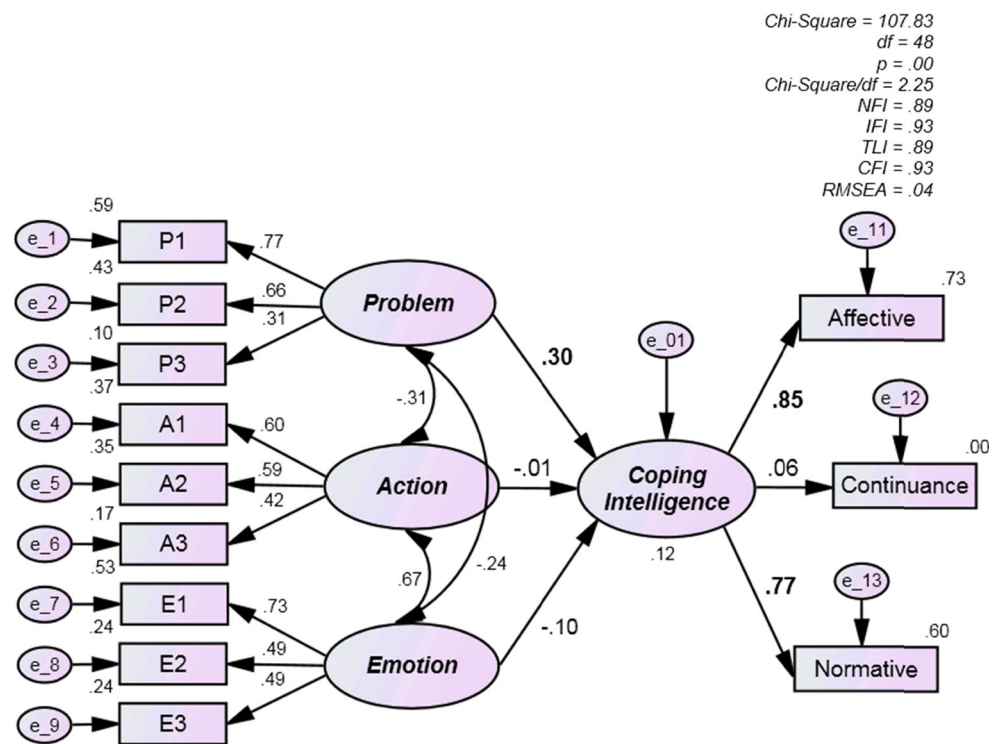
Fig. 2 Coping intelligence: coping strategies and organizational commitment (a reflective model)



continuance commitment (OC-C = .04, non-significant (n.s.)), and normative commitment (OC-N = .74). The fit was not adequate. Second, we turn to our *formative* model

which has a much better fit (Table 2, Model 4, Fig. 3) than that of our reflective model. Problem-focused coping (CI-P = .30), action-focused coping (CI-A = -.01, n.s.), and

Fig. 3 Coping intelligence: coping strategies and organizational commitment (a formative model)



emotion-focused coping (CI-E = $-.10$, n.s.) defined CI, that, in turn, was related to affective commitment (.85), continuance commitment (.06, n.s.), and normative commitment (.77). Thus, salespeople's problem-focused coping (CI-P) is significantly related to high affective commitment and normative commitment.

Our formative model (Fig. 3) reveals additional insights. The *lowest* correlation among the three sub-constructs of coping strategies was between problem-focused coping (CI-P) and emotion-focused coping (CI-E) ($r = -.24$), suggesting that both problem-focused coping and emotion-focused coping can make independent and separate contributions to the overall CI construct. On the other hand, action-focused coping, is strongly correlated with both problem-focused coping ($-.31$) and emotion-focused coping (.67). Please also note that the paths between action-focused coping (CI-A) and CI and between CI and continuance commitment (OC-C) were both non-significant in our model (Fig. 3). In order to perform subsequent analyses with additional control variables and develop a more parsimonious model than before, we further eliminated one coping intelligence component (action-focused coping, CI-A) and one outcome variable (continuance commitment, OC-C) based on results discussed above. We, then, retested our Coping Intelligence model.

For our *reflective* model, CI has two sub-constructs: Problem-focused coping (CI-P = .31) and emotion-focused

coping (CI-E = $-.22$) and two organizational commitment sub-constructs: Affective commitment (.92) and normative commitment (.71). The fit was reasonably good (Table 2, Model 5; Fig. 4). Our *formative* model provided excellent results (Table 2, Model 6; Fig. 5). Problem-focused coping (CI-P = .26) and emotion-focused coping (CI-E = $-.16$) contributed significantly to Coping Intelligence (CI) which is significantly related to organizational commitment: Affective commitment (.94) and normative commitment (.70). The correlation between problem-focused coping (CI-P) and emotion-focused coping (CI-E) was $-.24$ which was significantly less than .80. That is, salespeople with positive problem-focused coping but negative emotion-focused coping tend to have high affective and normative organizational commitment.

Control for Gender and Performance

Gender

After controlling for gender (Table 2, Model 7; Fig. 6), the results were very similar to our previous finding. Salespeople with positive problem-focused coping (CI-A = .27) but negative emotion-focused coping (CI-E = $-.15$) tend to have high affective (OC-A = .92) and normative organizational commitment (OC-N = .71). In addition, gender (females) was related to the use two emotional coping

Fig. 4 Coping intelligence: coping strategies and organizational commitment (a simplified reflective model)

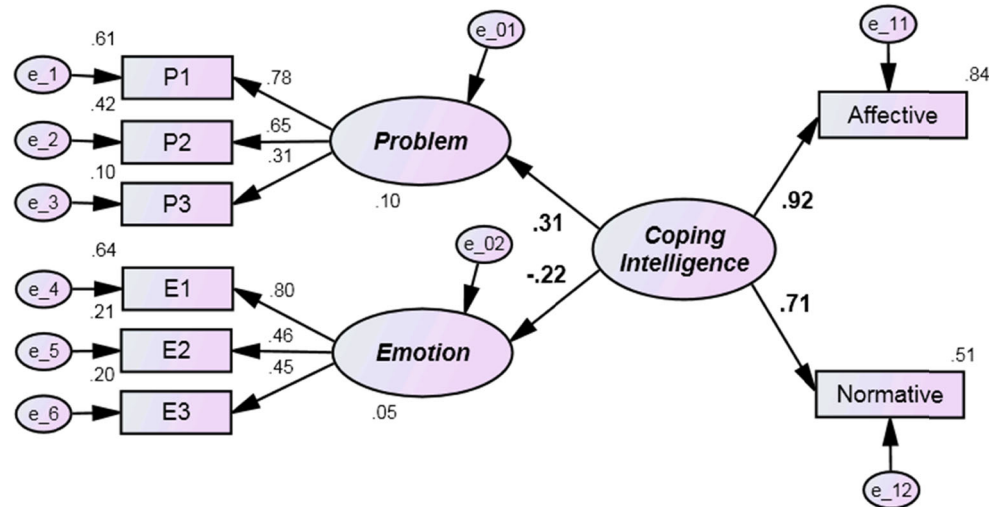


Fig. 5 Coping intelligence: coping strategies and organizational commitment (a simplified formative model)

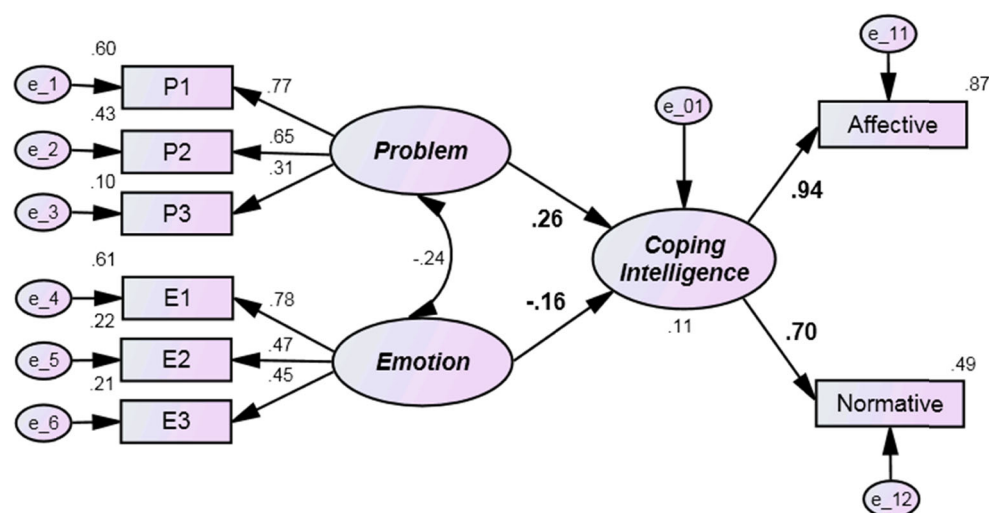
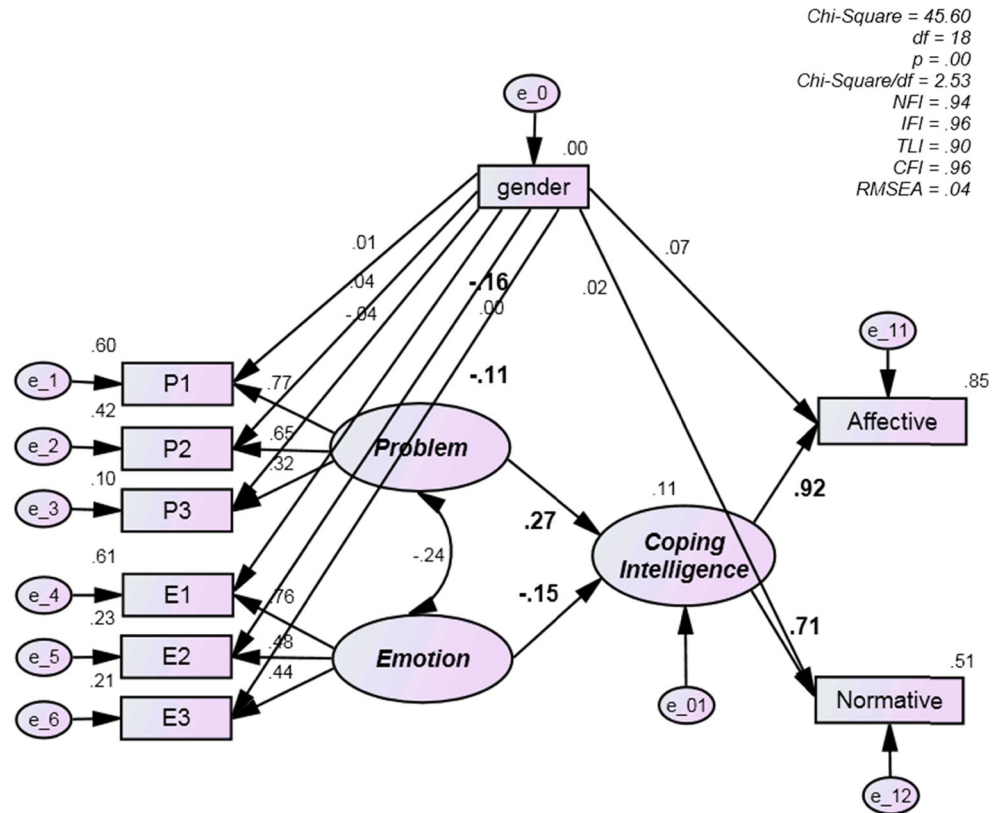


Fig. 6 Coping intelligence: coping strategies and organizational commitment (control for gender)



strategy items: Item 7 ($E1 = -.16$, I hope a miracle will happen) and Item 9 ($E3 = -.11$, Have fantasies about how things would work out) (“Appendix”) but was not associated with organizational commitment (OC-A and OC-N).

Performance (Sales Commission)

After we controlled for salespeople’s performance, the results remained significant (Table 2, Model 8; Fig. 7). Boundary spanning employees’ positive problem-focused coping ($CI-A = .26$) and negative emotion-focused coping ($CI-E = -.16$) were significantly associated with high affective commitment ($OC-A = .93$) and normative organizational commitment ($OC-N = .69$). Furthermore, their high performance (sales commission) was significantly related to both Affective commitment ($OC-A = .13$) and Normative commitment ($OC-N = .19$), but was not related to coping strategies (CI-P and CI-E).

Discussion

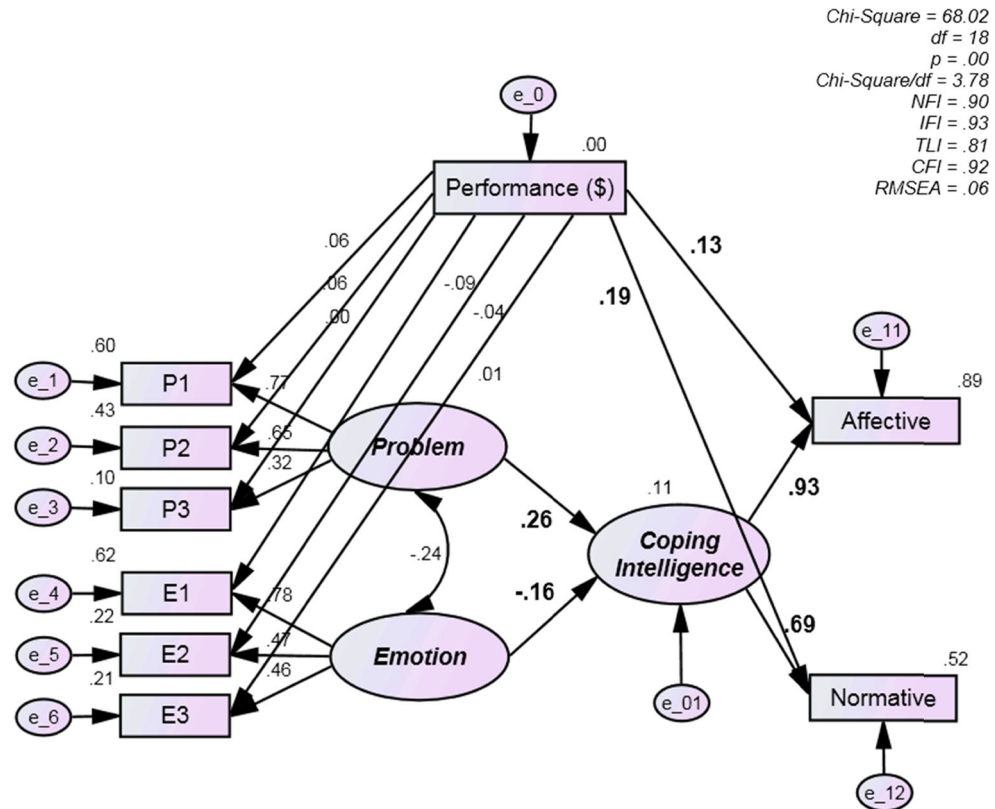
In this study, we develop a theoretical model of Coping Intelligence and explore the relationships between three types of coping strategies—problem-focused coping (CI-P),

action-focused coping (CI-A), and emotion-focused coping (CI-E) and three components of organizational commitment—Affective Commitment (OC-A), Continuance Commitment (OC-C), and Normative Commitment (OC-N). Based on 452 sales professionals of an international manufacturer of specialty chemical products in the US, we test our model using the whole sample. This research offers the following theoretical, empirical, and practical contributions.

Theoretical Contribution

We carefully refine the coping scale and select three items each for problem-focused (CI-P), action-focused (CI-A), and emotion-focused (CI-E) strategies and achieve excellent goodness of fit between our (reflective) measurement model and our data (Fig. 1). Future researchers will have confidence in using this short 9-item, 3-factor coping strategy scale (“Appendix”) and apply it with different work-related variables and constructs and in various contexts. On the basis of these findings, we develop a new theoretical model of Coping Intelligence (CI) and compare the model using both a reflective model and a formative model. In order to achieve model identification, we select three sub-constructs of the organizational commitment for this study. We explore the Coping Intelligence (CI)

Fig. 7 Coping intelligence: coping strategies and organizational commitment (control for performance—sales commission)



construct and investigate the relationships between three sub-constructs of coping strategy and three sub-constructs of organizational commitment: affective commitment (OC-A), continuous commitment (OC-C), and normative commitment (OC-N). We further revise our theoretical model and delete action-focused (CI-A) coping strategy and continuous commitment (OC-C) due to non-significant findings in the present study. We speculate that for some of these sales personnel, it may be quite easy to find a job elsewhere. Thus, the lack of employment alternatives is not an issue for them. This also reflects employees' short organizational tenure and relatively low annual retention rate (slightly below 50 % at the time of this study). These factors contribute to the non-significant finding related to continuous commitment. Therefore, the continuous commitment construct deserves researchers' future attention in the literature (Taing et al. 2011). We demonstrate that our formative model provides a much better fit than our reflective model, supporting the literature (Chen et al. 2013; Tang and Sutarso 2013). Our formative theoretical model of Coping Intelligence (CI) reveals the following novel findings.

First, among the sub-constructs, problem-focused coping (CI-P) contributes positively but emotion-focused

coping (CI-E) contributes negatively toward these sales personnel's affective commitment (OC-A) and normative commitment (OC-N). The correlation between problem-focused coping (CI-P) and emotion-focused coping (CI-E) is *negative* and relatively low ($|- .24| < .80$). We offer the following theoretical implications. The sub-components of coping strategies are not exchangeable and can make independent and separate contributions toward the overall latent construct—Coping Intelligence (CI). Further, some sub-components may make positive contributions, whereas others may make negative contributions toward CI, depending on the theoretically appropriate outcome variables. Our results suggest that in order to enhance boundary spanning employees' organizational commitment— affective commitment and normative commitment, in particular, managers must take the “approach” coping method (Moos 1993, 1995; Moos et al. 1990; Sardžoska and Tang 2014), adopt problem-focused coping strategy (CI-P), and actively solve the problems in a timely manner. At the same time, they should strongly avoid the “avoidance” method and the emotion-focused strategy (CI-E) (Sardžoska and Tang 2014).

Second, after controlling for gender, the same pattern of relationships also emerges using our theoretical model.

Therefore, our implications mentioned above continue to prevail for these participants. It is also interesting to note that females tend to use emotion-focused coping (CI-E), whereas males do not. The two emotion-focused coping items strongly associated with gender (female) are Item 7 (I hope a miracle will happen) and Item 9 (Have fantasies about how things would work out). Thus, females may have a stronger tendency to visualize miracles and fantasize delightful or ideal outcomes and spend time on (or preoccupied with) daydreaming than males. It is speculated that female sales personnel's activities may not reduce stress, solve problems, but may corrupt their Coping Intelligence which, in turn, may hurt their organizational commitment. Our model also illustrates that gender is not associated with affective organizational commitment (OC-A) and normative organizational commitment (OC-N) in this sample. Thus, there are some revealing gender differences regarding emotion-focused coping, but no major gender differences regarding organizational commitment.

Third, the pattern of our theoretical model controlling for salespeople's commission (objective performance data obtained from the organizations' personnel records) is different from that of controlling for gender, although relationships between coping and commitment remain the same. Our compensation literature suggests that high pay leads to high pay satisfaction consistently (Milkovich et al. 2014; Luna-Arocas and Tang 2014; Tang and Chiu 2003; Tang et al. 2006b). As expected, when individuals obtain high sales commission (high income), they are likely to experience high pay satisfaction. High pay satisfaction spills over to their satisfaction with what they do and where they work which may lead to their high affective commitment and normative commitment. As a consequence, they want to stay and remain at the current organization. In this study, our salespeoples' *objective financial data*, obtained from the official personnel record, i.e., from a different source, do make a significant contribution to our theoretical model. It helps us understand the strong relationships between their *objective* sales commission and their *subjective* self-reported feelings toward organizations—organizational commitment. Interestingly enough, these people's sales performance is not related to their coping strategy. Taken together, gender is related to coping strategy (CI-E), but sales commission is not. On the other hand, sales commission is related to both aspects of commitment (OC-A and OC-N), but gender is not. Thereby, employees' gender and objective performance (sales commission) in an organization do provide innovative, fresh, and critical information to our theoretical model of Coping Intelligence among sales personnel in this study. Future researchers may want to explore these mechanisms and additional variables and empirically tease out the novel notions of Coping Intelligence.

Empirical Contribution

We obtained subjective survey data and objective performance measure (sales commission) from two different sources regarding full-time boundary spanning employees in the organization. The sample size was reasonably good in this study. Our theoretical model involves a *formative* model of Coping Intelligence and organizational commitment and provides additional insights and interesting answers to questions than a *reflective* model. We also include gender and sales commission as control variables. The good measurement properties provide the generalizability of our findings and scholars' confidence in applying these measures in other samples, regions, and countries around the world.

Practical Contribution

Boundary spanning employees play an important role in working under the constraints of the organizations' internal as well as external environment (Edmondson and Boyer 2013; Robertson 1995). They are responsible for delivering quality products and services, customer satisfaction, and performance for organizations (Mulki et al. 2012). As a consequence, they may experience a high level of work-related stress. Our research suggests that if they apply problem-focused coping strategy and avoid emotion-focused coping strategy, then, they may be able to cope with their daily stress successfully, complete work-related task effectively and efficiently, make abundant money for themselves, increase profits for the organization, and have high levels of affective commitment and normative commitment. In summary, they need to take action and solve the problems effectively and efficiently and cannot avoid the problems (Sardžoska and Tang 2014).

We provide additional speculations and implications below. First, we turn to problem-focused coping response pattern. In order to cope with work-related issues and stress, people in organizations may adopt numerous problem-solving and decision-making tools and techniques to identify both sources of and solutions to these problems (Tang 2014a). Second, although salespeople may work independently and are paid based on commissions (Milkovich et al. 2014), individuals do not work alone by themselves, completely. They do have managers and colleagues and work in various groups or teams, such as: problem-solving teams, continuous improvement teams, quality circles, self-managing teams, and self-directing teams (e.g., Foote and Tang 2008; Tang et al. 1987, 1989). Team members with diverse backgrounds and experiences may provide novel, innovative, and creative solutions, share information and tacit knowledge about their products, services, customers, and different organizations and make

significant contributions to many work-related attitudes and behaviors in different contexts. In the general area of total quality management, managers may teach sales team members to use fishbone analysis, for example, and trace any problems or issues back to their original sources related to the four Ms: Manpower, Material, Machine, and Method. Although some natural resources may be limited and costly, but ideas, innovations, and creativity are limitless and readily available, with proper training and development (Tang 2010).

According to Cohen and Levinthal's (1990) absorptive capacity theory of knowledge acquisition, individuals with more accumulated prior knowledge and strong problem-solving skills are more likely to recognize and acquire new external knowledge, put new knowledge in memory, exploit new relevant information, recall the information, utilize it in new settings, and become creative than those without. This theory, obviously, is applicable to peoples' problem-solving and coping strategy in organizations, including people in sales. Creativity, defined as the generation of novel and useful ideas, is a social process and consists of three major components: (1) expertise, (2) creative-thinking skills, and (3) motivation (Amabile 1998). Further, environmental factors—(1) encouragement of creativity, (2) autonomy or freedom, (3) resources, (4) pressures, and (5) organizational impediments to creativity—also affect creativity (Amabile and Conti 1999).

Furthermore, moral leadership is positively related to employee identification with leader which greatly enhances leader-member exchange which leads to high creativity (Gu et al. 2013). Moral managers must set excellent role models, create a culture of innovation, develop training programs to enhance employees' creativity, innovation, and critical thinking skills (Howard et al. 2014), accelerate formal and informal social interaction, facilitate interpersonal communication, spark new ideas, provide resources, time and money, and help them solve problems creatively. When people work together in teams to achieve organizational goals (Foote and Tang 2008), they may encounter conflicts. Following the five conflict handling styles—avoiding, accommodating, forcing, compromising, and collaborating, it is important to instill values and create win-win-win situations for all stakeholders (self, other, the organization, and environment).¹ Managers need to be aware of the "dark side" of creativity (Gino and Ariely 2012; Malhotra and Gino 2011). Some may apply their creative mind-set; store up for themselves treasures on earth; and become *bad apples* (Kish-Gephart et al. 2010).

Third, we include the issue of objective financial performance (sales commission) as a control variable. Sardžoska

and Tang (2014) found, among 515 Macedonian managers, that *positive* affective love of money motive (MI-A) and *positive* stewardship behavior (MI-B) are related to stronger behavioral and cognitive "approach" coping strategies and weaker behavioral and cognitive "avoidance" coping strategies. Further, their *negative* stewardship behavior (MI-B) and *positive* cognitive meaning (MI-C) lead to unethical intentions. Thus, positive stewardship behavior leads to positive and desirable outcomes, whereas negative stewardship behavior directs people to low levels of satisfaction with pay and life and a high level of unethical intentions (Tang et al. 2011, 2013). The combination of these aforementioned studies and our current research appears to posit that those faithful stewards who take action and adopt the "approach" coping method and solving problems effectively and efficiently will obtain positive outcomes. On the other hand, the lack of these proactive and problem-focused coping strategies may steer them to lower commitment and possibly unethical intentions and behaviors². When tempted, it is easy to fall into temptation, lose self-control,³ and become corrupt (Chen et al. 2013; Tang and Sutarso 2013), for the love of money is the love of all evils⁴ (DeTienne et al. 2012; Tang and Chiu 2003; Tang et al. 2011). It is important, for managers, to monitor salespeople's love of money motives, satisfaction, and work-related pressures and opportunities in organizations and remove all factors which may contribute to temptation and unethical behaviors.

Finally, regarding gender, females are less committed than their male counterparts among recreation and park professionals in the US (Cunningham et al. 2012; Tang et al. 2012). Further, females fall into temptation due to lack of self-control and cognitive impairment (Tang and Sutarso 2013), whereas males engage unethical behaviors on purpose and display their malicious intentions. In addition, males who consider money as power and females who do not manage their money carefully are likely to focus on materialism and try to impress others and show off in the social context (Lemrová et al. 2013). Since females are more likely to engage in emotion-focused coping behaviors than males, our findings seem to support the notion indirectly that females are more emotional and do things impulsively than their male counterparts. Thus, managers may provide training programs to emphasize solving problems rather than fantasizing or daydreaming in work-related settings.

¹ "Tell them to do good, to be rich in good works, to be generous, ready to share". (1 Timothy 6: 18).

² "To anyone who has, more will be given and he will grow rich; from anyone who has not, even what he has will be taken away". (Matthew 13: 12).

³ "tempt you through your lack of self-control". (1 Corinthians 7: 5).

⁴ "Those who want to get rich are falling into temptation and into a trap and into many foolish and harmful desires, which plunge them into ruin and destruction. For the love of money is the root of all evils." (1 Timothy 6: 9-10).

Limitations

Although we collect data from multiple sources, both constructs, examined in our theoretical model, come from participants' survey results completed at one time. Following suggestions in the literature (Podsakoff et al. 2003), results of Harman's single-factor test suggest that the CMV issue is not a major concern in our study. In addition, we employ different scale anchors for these two measures to enhance the psychological separation of the predictors and the criteria (Podsakoff et al. 2003). Our cross-sectional survey data from a single source do not provide a strong cause-and-effect relationship. We collected data from only sales personnel (boundary spanning employees) in one organization in the US. Due to the nature of this organization, the type of product they sell, and the way they sell their products, future researchers may want to empirically verify our findings based on this theoretical model using people in different organizations, type of industries, and cultures.

Conclusion

We develop a theoretical model of Coping Intelligence (CI) and explore relationships between coping strategies and organizational commitment. Based on data collected from multiple sources from 452 employees, we examine a short, parsimonious 9-item, 3-factor coping strategy measure with good measurement properties. Our parsimonious formative model of Coping Intelligence (CI) demonstrates that positive problem-focused coping but negative emotion-focused coping contribute to both affective and normative commitment. After controlling for gender and sales commission, independently, results remain significant and provide additional novel discoveries. Females are likely to use emotion-focused coping than males. Salespeople's commission is positively related to both affective and normative commitment. However, gender is not related to organizational commitment, whereas sales commission is not related to coping strategies. We shed new lights on boundary spanning employees' coping intelligence and organizational commitment and offer important theoretical, empirical, and practical implications regarding Coping Intelligence and business ethics. More research is needed in this direction to further explore not only the antecedents or individual difference variables (e.g., locus of control, social support, and self-efficacy) but also various positive (e.g., satisfaction) and negative (e.g., burnout and withdrawal) consequences of coping strategies to establish a wide nomological network of relationships for Coping Intelligence.

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Appendix: Coping Strategies

Problem-focused coping (CI-P)

1. I try to work more efficiently
2. I devote more time and energy to my job
3. Decide what I think should be done and explain this to the people who are affected.

Action-focused (escape, mental disengagement) coping (CI-A)

4. Watch TV
5. Eat snacks
6. I take it out on family or friends by getting angry at them

Emotion-focused coping (CI-E)

7. I hope a miracle will happen
8. I try to forget the whole thing
9. Have fantasies about how things would work out

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